THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Change Your Desires, Not Just Your Deeds

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapters 2-3

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapters 2 and 3
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 20 February 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we left off

The Rabbi began with a review of the introduction and Chapter 1. There is one human soul with five faculties, from lowest to highest: nutrition, the senses, imagination, the emotional or appetitive faculty, and the intellect, which is either practical or theoretical. Animals share the first two in name only. A person who never develops the intellect is matter without form. The chapters build on each other, he said, so Chapter 1 must be clear before Chapter 2.

He called Chapter 2 short but transformative: "If you understand this chapter properly, it will change your entire perspective of Torah, of religion, of behaviour."

Which part of the soul does the Torah speak to?

Before reading, the Rabbi asked the class which faculty a person must work on to improve his behaviour. One answer was the fourth, the emotions, and he agreed. Then the Rambam:

All the misvot and aveirot of the Torah, the positive and the negative commands, concern only two faculties: **the senses (2)** and **the emotional faculty (4)**.

The Torah does not address **nutrition (1)** or **imagination (3)**, because we have no choice over them. The Rambam's proof is that both continue while we sleep. Digestion goes on and dreams come, but there is no sensing, desiring or reasoning in sleep. Something that happens by itself cannot be commanded.

What about the intellect? There are a few commands of belief, which belong to the fifth faculty. But the do's and don'ts, the great majority of the Torah, belong to faculties 2 and 4.

Desire leads, the senses follow

The Rabbi worked through examples: - **Hatred and revenge.** The Torah forbids hating another person or bearing a grudge. These are clearly matters of faculty 4. - **Forbidden food.** I walk past a shop and want to eat non-kosher meat. The wanting is faculty 4. Reaching out and eating is faculty 2, which carries out what faculty 4 decides. - **Lighting a fire on Shabbat.** I am cold and want warmth (4), so I strike a match (2).

A participant asked whether intention, *kavanah*, which comes from the intellect, also matters. The Rabbi agreed that intention embellishes a misvah, but the root of the action itself lies in faculties 2 and 4. Another participant observed that everything really starts with desire. "A hundred percent," said the Rabbi. The Rambam calls the sensory faculty a servant, a *shamash*, of the emotional faculty: whatever faculty 4 tells it to do, it does.

He showed a passage from the Moreh Nevuchim that makes the same point: having an idea of something does not move us. Only when desire arises do we act. The idea comes from faculty 5, it must become a desire in faculty 4, and only then does faculty 2 act.

Two kinds of virtue

The Rambam distinguishes virtues of the intellect from virtues of character.

Virtues of the intellect belong to faculty 5. He gives three: knowing causes and reasons (the Rabbi's example was a law of physics); self-evident truths that need no proof, such as that two is even or that a whole is greater than its part; and quickness of understanding.

Virtues of character, *middot*, come only from faculty 4, with faculty 2 serving it. The Rambam lists restraint, generosity, integrity, humility, contentment with one's lot ("this is true wealth"), courage and more. The vices are lacking these traits or exaggerating them. Even a good trait taken too far is a fault, which will be the subject of Chapter 4.

Faculties 1 and 3 have no virtue or vice at all. We can only say they work well or badly, as one says a person has good or bad digestion. The Rabbi gave Aristotle's example: a "good sofa" is not morally good. It is comfortable and does its job.

Why this changes everything

This, said the Rabbi, is the key. The Torah and God are mainly interested in faculty 4, our will and desire. Many people take on another misvah and another stringency, which is wonderful, but they are working only on faculty 2. "You can spend your whole life doing more misvot… but you haven't dealt with the root of it."

He used this to answer a famous question: why does Rosh Hashanah come before Yom Kippur? Should we not atone first and then be judged? Rosh Hashanah is about who you are, your identity, which is faculty 4. Yom Kippur is about what you did, the list of actions, which is faculty 2. First we look at who we are, then at our deeds. He said he had taught this idea for years, but studying this chapter showed him its depth.

Two more examples: - **Distance yourself from falsehood.** The Torah says *midvar sheker tirhak*: not only do not lie, but keep far from falsehood. The Rabbi cited the Vilna Gaon's view that even indirectly causing deception is forbidden by the Torah, although normally indirect causation (*grama*) carries no Torah liability. How does a person reach that level? Not through rules alone, but by building the trait of integrity in faculty 4. - **Do not fear any man.** The Torah warns judges not to favour someone out of fear. A judge can resolve not to, but under real pressure resolutions can give way. A person who has built the trait of courage, *gevurah*, will not be tempted in the first place.

The Rambam himself writes that the greatest teshuvah is teshuvah from *deot*, from character traits, not only from actions. The Rabbi's conclusion: education, for our children and for

ourselves, has to be about character, not only about "do this, don't do that." In the questions, one participant said people go through the High Holy Days every year without changing. The Rabbi agreed: focusing only on actions has a limit. Real change comes from faculty 4, and that is much harder work.

Chapter 3: health and illness of the soul

The ancients, the Rambam says, taught that the soul can be healthy or ill, just like the body. A healthy soul tends towards good deeds; an ill soul tends towards bad ones.

The analogy is medical. A sick person may taste sweet as bitter and bitter as sweet, and may even crave things that harm him. The Rabbi admitted that most of us are a little like this, giving Coca-Cola as his example: we think it sweet, but for our health it is bitter. In the same way, a person with an ill soul thinks vice is virtue and virtue is vice.

So the sick person goes to a doctor, who forbids what he thinks is good and makes him take what he thinks is bitter until he recovers. The spiritually ill person must go to the *hakhamim*, the healers of souls, whose method the Rambam will give in Chapter 4.

The Rabbi stressed that this is not about mental illness such as depression or anxiety, which the Rambam does not discuss here. It is about defects in faculty 4, in our desires and emotions, which we all have.

Three kinds of patient

The Rambam describes: - **Those who know they are ill and go to the doctor.** These are the ones Chapter 4 will help. - **Those who know they are ill but cannot stop**, like an addict or a smoker. The Torah describes such a person saying "I will follow my own heart," but it only makes the thirst worse. - **Those who do not know they are ill.** This is the worst. The Rabbi compared it to an illness found too late. The Rambam quotes Mishlei: "The way of a fool is straight in his own eyes, but the wise man listens to advice," and "The way of the wicked is like darkness; they do not know what they stumble on."

The Rabbi said honestly that most people live in this third category. We are all ill to some degree. The first step is to know it.

Summary

- The Torah's commands are directed to two faculties: the emotions (4) and the senses (2). Nutrition and imagination run by themselves, so they are neither good nor bad.
- Desire leads and the senses serve it, so the root of behaviour is faculty 4.
- Changing actions is not enough. Real teshuvah and education work on character, as Rosh Hashanah (who we are) comes before Yom Kippur (what we did).
- The soul, like the body, can be ill, and needs the advice of a healer of souls.
- The worst illness is the one we do not know we have.

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